

Uses



This light, strong china contains calcium phosphate.

China tea set

Spraying ammonium phosphate over burning material cuts off its supply of oxygen. This extinguishes the fire.



Fire extinguisher

Safety match box



These flexible fibres are composed of phosphate-rich glass.

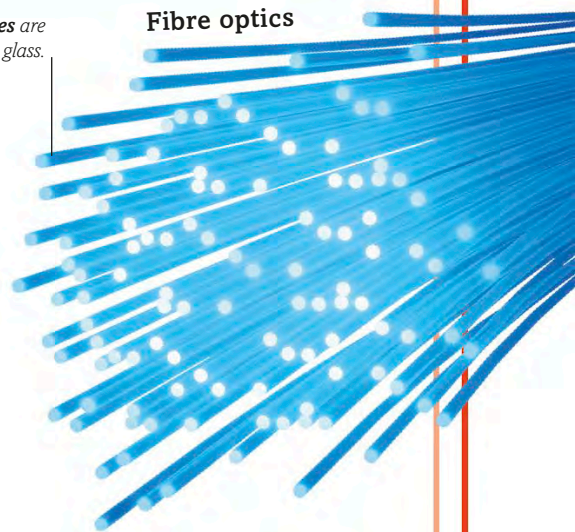
The striking surface on the sides of the box contains phosphorus, which ignites the match upon contact.

Spraying crops with phosphates kills pests, such as insects.



Pesticides

Fibre optics



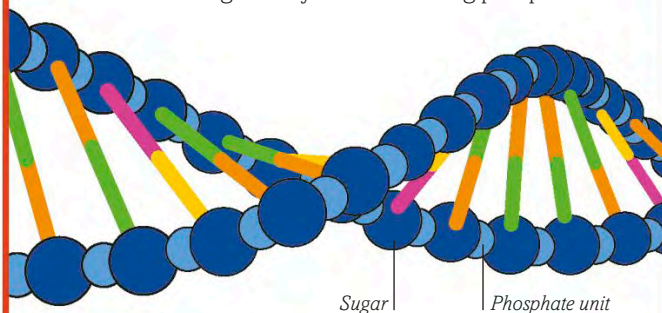
Fertilizer



This fertilizer contains ammonium phosphate to boost plant growth.

LIFE'S BUILDING BLOCKS

DNA – short for deoxyribonucleic acid – is like a mini database packed with instructions telling your body how to work properly. It consists of a chain of molecules and looks like a twisted ladder called a double helix. The edges are sugar molecules linked together by units containing phosphorus.



Sugar

Phosphate unit

solid forms, including **red**, **white**, black, and **violet**. The glow seen by Brand was caused by white phosphorus reacting with oxygen. Phosphorus is mainly found in **phosphate** minerals (in which phosphorus links to oxygen), such as **apatite**, its main ore.

Phosphates are present in **fine china**, and are an important ingredient in **fertilizers**. The strips on the sides of **safety match boxes** contain pure phosphorus. More complex phosphorus compounds used in **pesticides** are poisonous.